

OPSCoconnect

Executive Summary

A secure, permission-based discovery and routing layer over approved OPS data sources, powered by Microsoft Copilot. It helps staff find the right person, skill, project or ticket context, and next step in seconds.

Version	1.0
Version Date	July 10, 2026
Track	1. Onboarding and Time-to-Productivity <i>(also advances Knowledge Retrieval and Request-Routing)</i>
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Executive Summary Statement: OPSCoconnect is a secure, permission-based workflow platform that uses ESMT, Forte, the Employee Directory, and Microsoft Copilot to help OPS staff identify the right support path, related ticket history, contact, expertise, and next step, turning hours of manual searching into seconds, while protecting restricted information.

The problem	Staff act on partial context (a ticket number, system, or problem) and lose time searching ESMT, Forte, email, Teams, and SharePoint to find the right owner, expert, or next step.
The solution	One Teams-native assistant that searches approved sources, has Copilot summarize and recommend, and applies a permission layer so results respect role and data-owner rules.
On-policy AI	Microsoft Copilot is the only AI , used for summarization and recommendation. Access-control decisions are made by the permission layer, never by the AI model.
Manager value	A live connection network, a coordinator analytics page, and a manager chat that together let leaders see silos, isolated staff, and knowledge risk, and act early.
3-year cost	~\$1.43M of the \$1.5M budget (about \$500k per year, front-loaded), with ~\$150k contingency.
Return	~\$4M or more per year in reclaimed staff time at conservative scale; payback under 6 months; over 2x ROI even at 25% of projections.

1. Problem to Solve

OPS staff often handle requests with only partial context: a ticket number, a system or application name, a deployment key, a problem description, or an affected user. The ownership, support, expertise, and historical information needed to act may exist, but it is spread across multiple internal systems and is not easy to discover together.

- Staff spend time searching ESMT, Forte, email, Teams, and SharePoint, or asking around informally.
- Requests are delayed or misrouted when the correct owner, support team, expert, or next step is unclear.
- Some information cannot be freely shared across teams because of privacy, security, and role-based restrictions.

Quantified impact: industry research (McKinsey) finds knowledge workers spend about 1.8 hours per day, close to 20% of the workweek, searching for information and tracking down colleagues. Across roughly 66,000 OPS staff, even a fraction of that time represents millions of dollars in recoverable capacity each year.

2. Proposed Solution

OPSCoConnect is a production-ready internal platform, delivered inside **Microsoft Teams** with a companion web experience, that acts as a **secure workflow layer over approved OPS data sources**. It does not replace ESMT, Forte, or existing systems. It helps staff use them more effectively.

- A user enters a problem, ticket number, system or application, deployment key, request type, or a plain-language question (for example, "who knows Tableau?", "who can staff HDP-482?", "I am a new co-op, who should I meet?").
- The platform searches ESMT, Forte, the Employee Directory, and other approved sources.
- Copilot summarizes relevant ticket history and expertise, then suggests a support path or the right people.
- A permission layer controls whether the user sees a contact, owner, support queue, or a restricted-information message.

The result: hours of searching become seconds, with the right answer, and the right access, the first time.

3. How It Works: the AI Workflow

OPSCoconnect follows one disciplined principle: **the AI routes and phrases, governed queries supply the facts, and the permission layer decides what may be shown.** The model never stores data, invents facts, or makes access decisions.

- **Route.** Copilot interprets the request and identifies the key items (ticket, system, skill, person, team).
- **Retrieve.** A purpose-built tool runs a read-only query against approved sources. Semantic search handles synonyms, so "k8s" resolves to "Kubernetes", when exact keywords fail.
- **Filter.** The permission layer applies role-based and data-owner rules before anything is shown.
- **Phrase.** Copilot composes a short, cited answer, and the app renders the result cards directly from the query, not from model text.

This delivers three things leadership cares about: **accuracy** (no invented facts), **compliance** (Microsoft-only AI, kept in the OPS tenant, no training on OPS data, access decisions outside the model), and **low cost** (most requests are inexpensive governed lookups, not large AI calls).

4. Current to Future Workflow

Current workflow	Future workflow with OPSCoconnect
Manual search across systems and informal channels.	Enter a ticket or problem, or ask in plain language, in one internal platform.
Ownership, expert, or support path may be unclear.	Platform recommends the team, contact path, related history, expertise, and next step.
Sensitive data can be over-shared or unavailable.	Permission-based results protect restricted information.
Follow-up depends on manual messages.	Feedback and an audit trail improve future routing accuracy.

A full current-state and future-state process map accompanies this summary as a supporting exhibit.

5. Capabilities Delivered

Capability	Value to the OPS
Ticket and support-path discovery (ESMT, Forte)	Right owner and next step; fewer misroutes and duplicate handoffs
Skill and expertise search	Faster problem-solving; less duplicated work
Project staffing and capability-gap detection	Right people on the right work; visible gaps
Org structure, roster, and reporting-line navigation	Cross-ministry wayfinding; reduced silos
Co-op and new-hire onboarding companion	Faster time-to-productivity (Track 1)

6. Value for Managers and Coordinators

Beyond individual lookups, OPSCoConnect gives team managers and program coordinators a live view of how their people connect, where knowledge sits, and where to act. Three tools work together to turn team management from reactive to proactive.

6.1 The connection network (a living map of nodes)

Every person is a node, and the links between them show how they connect. A manager can change what a link means, and the whole picture updates instantly:

Connection lens	What it reveals
Logged connection (coffee chat)	Who has actually met and collaborated
Same team, division, or ministry	How tightly a group works together, and where it is fragmented
Shared skills	Hidden expertise clusters and who to pair on a problem
Same project	Real working groups across reporting lines
Reporting line	The formal structure, side by side with the informal one

At a glance a manager can see who is **isolated or newly arrived and not yet connected**, who **bridges the most ministries** (the informal connectors worth retaining), where a **skill depends on a single person** (a continuity and knowledge risk), and how well a team actually collaborates.

6.2 The coordinator analytics page

A leadership view that reads in thirty seconds: adoption and active users, cross-team and cross-ministry collaboration, most and least connected teams, knowledge concentration and gaps, and onboarding health for new co-ops. It doubles as a change-management scorecard, so leaders can measure whether silos are shrinking and newcomers are integrating over time.

6.3 The manager chat (plain-language analytics)

Managers ask questions in ordinary language and get grounded answers, with no dashboards to learn:

- "Who on my team is isolated or needs a nudge to connect?"
- "How are Priya and Marcus connected?" and "Who could introduce me to someone in the Ministry of Health?"
- "Who should our new co-op meet first?"
- "Which of our active projects have staffing gaps, and who can fill them?"
- "Which skills does our team rely on only one person for?"
- "Draft a short note to reconnect two people."

Together these give every manager the insight of a dedicated network analyst: balancing workloads, breaking silos, reducing knowledge risk, accelerating onboarding, and building deliberate cross-team bridges.

7. Infrastructure and Data Approach

OPSCoconnect uses a hybrid internal OPS hosting model connected to approved GDC and data-centre infrastructure. The frontend never queries ESMT or Forte directly. All access flows through secure API, integration, and permission layers.

Component	Purpose
Frontend web app (in Teams)	Intake for a ticket, problem, or question; routing results; profile and availability.
API and integration layer	Connects the frontend to ESMT, Forte, the Employee Directory, and Copilot (read-only).
Permission layer	Applies role-based and data-owner rules before any result is displayed.
Application database	Preferences, availability, feedback, audit logs, permission mappings, and limited cache only.
Monitoring and logging	Tracks access, health, errors, security events, and routing performance.

Variable cost, other ticketing systems: ESMT and Forte are the primary approved sources, but some teams use different tools such as Jira and Confluence, Azure DevOps, or ServiceNow. Each additional system is a separate read-only connector (about \$15k to \$25k, one to two weeks) added case by case as teams onboard. This is a variable line, isolated so it never blocks core delivery.

8. Security, Privacy, and AI Governance

- Login through OPS account and ontario.ca identity with single sign-on and role-based access control.
- No sensitive cross-team data exposure unless approved by a manager or data owner.
- Audit logging for searches, viewed results, approvals, and administrative actions.
- Encryption in transit and at rest, with retention rules for search history and audit records.
- All data and inference remain in the OPS tenant (Canada). Copilot does not train on OPS data.
- **Microsoft Copilot is used only as the approved AI layer for summarization and recommendation. Access-control decisions remain outside the AI model.**
- Built to WCAG 2.2 AA. Accessibility and change management are addressed through simple UI design, user guidance, pilot feedback, and phased rollout.

9. Implementation Roadmap

Phase	Timeline	Focus and deliverables
1. Discovery and Design	FY2026-27	Confirm data sources, permission model, integration method, and success metrics; complete PIA and TRA.
2. Foundation Build	FY2026-27	Environments, authentication, frontend, API layer, database, and logging; assistant live in Teams.
3. Data Integration	FY2027-28	Read-only connectors to ESMT, Forte, Employee Directory, and Copilot; connection network and coordinator analytics.
4. Pilot and Rollout	FY2027-29	Validate with selected OPS teams, improve accuracy, then expand adoption across ministries.

10. Cost Analysis and Financial Feasibility

Costed bottom-up on fully-loaded OPS salaries (base times 1.40 for pension, benefits, and overhead) and deliberately staffed with permanent staff and co-op students rather than contractors. At Ontario I and IT Vendor-of-Record day rates, a contractor team would cost roughly 1.4 to 2 times more and would breach the \$500k annual cap. The program fits by reusing OPS-approved infrastructure, identity services, the ESMT and Forte sources, and Microsoft Copilot, rather than building a separate system.

Cost area	3-year estimate	Notes
Development and implementation team (staff plus co-ops)	\$1,046k	Lean team of 2.8 down to 2.2 FTE; about 83% of base
Infrastructure, hosting, and monitoring	\$126k	Marginal consumption on existing platform
ESMT, Forte, Directory, and Copilot integration	\$52k	Read-only connectors and SDK (variable)
Security, privacy, and accessibility review	\$34k	PIA and TRA, WCAG 2.2 AA audit, penetration test
Training and change management	\$22k	In-Teams rollout, champions network
Contingency (about 12%)	\$150k	Integration surprises and scope growth
Total (3 years)	\$1,430k	About \$500k per year, front-loaded (Y1 \$500k, Y2 \$470k, Y3 \$310k); under the \$1.5M ceiling

11. Return on Investment

Conservative model. Reclaiming just 10 minutes per active user per week, a fraction of the 1.8 hours per day lost today:

- About 10,000 active users by FY2028-29 (roughly 15% of the OPS) gives about 77,000 hours per year reclaimed, or about \$4.2M per year at a loaded rate near \$55 per hour.
- Onboarding acceleration: removing even 3 ramp-up days for about 2,000 new hires and co-ops per year adds roughly \$2M per year.
- Payback under 6 months at scale, and about 9 to 10 times annual return against the roughly \$310k per year steady-state run cost.
- Sensitivity: even at 25% of projected adoption and savings, the program still returns more than 2 times its total cost.

In short: about \$1.43M invested against a conservatively estimated \$4M or more per year in reclaimed productivity, effectively self-funding within its first year at scale, plus qualitative gains in onboarding speed, fewer misrouted tickets, lower knowledge-loss risk, and stronger cross-ministry collaboration.

12. Success Measures

Brief metric	OPSCoconnect KPI	Target
Processing time	Time to find the correct team, contact, or answer	Hours to under 60 sec
Task completion	Requests resolved without escalation or re-routing	80% or more
Information accessibility	Active users; share of answers grounded and cited	Rising; 100% grounded
Follow-through reliability	Routing-recommendation accuracy (user feedback)	Improving
Onboarding (Track 1)	New-hire time to first 10 connections	Down 50% or more
Governance	Compliance with privacy, audit, and permission rules	100%

13. Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Low adoption	Delivered inside Teams (no new tool to learn); champions network; adoption metrics steer rollout
Restricted-data exposure	Permission layer and data-owner approval; aggregate, coordinator-gated analytics; full audit logging
Source and ticketing variety	Read-only connector SDK; variable, incremental funding for each new system
Budget overrun	Staff and co-op staffing; reuse of the approved platform; about 16% combined contingency and headroom
Small-team key-person risk	Co-op talent pipeline; documented, standards-based build

14. Conclusion

OPSCoconnect provides a practical, on-policy way to improve OPS internal workflow. It turns partial ticket or problem information, or a plain-language question, into a secure recommendation for the right support path, expertise, related history, and next step. It uses existing OPS systems as the sources of truth while adding a governed discovery and routing layer on top, powered only by Microsoft Copilot.

For managers and coordinators, the connection network, the analytics page, and the manager chat give a clear, live picture of how teams collaborate, where knowledge is concentrated, and who needs support, so leaders can act before small gaps become real problems.

Already prototyped, staffed sustainably with OPS talent and co-op students, and funded within budget with meaningful contingency, OPSCoconnect converts one of the OPS's most common frictions from hours into seconds, for about \$1.43M against a conservatively estimated \$4M or more per year in reclaimed productivity.

We recommend proceeding with the Phase 1 discovery, design, and pilot.